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## ***Tolkien as a Literary Artist: Exploring Rhetoric, Language and Style in The Lord of the Rings* by Thomas Kullmann and Dirk Siepmann**

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***Tolkien as a Literary Artist: Exploring Rhetoric, Language and Style in The Lord of the Rings*** by Thomas Kullmann and Dirk Siepmann

with." "These tales," as Ball continues, "help us deal with the irresolvable dilemmas of being human" (379, italics in original). For those of us who care about mythopoeic fiction, this is a ringing endorsement of the significance of what we study.

—Janet Brennan Croft



**TOLKIEN AS A LITERARY ARTIST: EXPLORING RHETORIC, LANGUAGE AND STYLE IN THE LORD OF THE RINGS.** Thomas Kullmann and Dirk Siepmann. Palgrave Macmillan, 2021. 319 p. 9783030692988. \$149.99.

DRS. KULLMANN AND SIEPMANN approach the topic of literary artistry in the works of Tolkien from the point of view of both linguistics and the history of literature, in which the author of *The Lord of the Rings* was so deeply educated. Given that Tolkien was foremost a philologist, analyzing his vocabulary and syntax makes sense. This approach forms a "corpus stylistic" treatment combined with discourse theory and intertextuality. The co-authors relate Tolkien's writing techniques to a wide-ranging corpus of English fiction as well as poetics; style and rhetoric, while traditional approaches, receive fresh treatment in this work as the authors bring out the role of languages in the world building that takes place through speeches, storytelling, descriptions of mythic landscapes, and the many poems and songs inserted into the narrative. Each type receives its own chapter. With a combination of a corpus-based linguistic analysis and a more traditional literary dissection of the text, they bring a nuanced and detailed study to the body of scholarly criticism surrounding Tolkien's work.

As the initiating premise, the authors portray Tolkien as caught between the Charybdis and Scylla of disdainful literary critics who ignore him and overly enthusiastic fans who idolize him. This dichotomy has kept him out of the mainstream of literary tradition and sidelined his writing, especially *The Lord of the Rings*, from receiving its due consideration. To rectify this situation the authors propose to examine the "rhetoric, story-telling, description and the malleability of English prose" (3) employed by Tolkien. Kullmann and Siepmann desire to place Tolkien, not on a pedestal, but rather on a shelf alongside other literary greats, and simply accord him the same critical consideration of linguistic and literary study.

They propose to undertake a standard, two-fold approach of qualitative and quantitative measures. This affords a heuristic that permits comparison with other similar works from normative literary canons: apples to

apples checkpoints, as it were. The quantitative approach employs corpus linguistic methods to assess Tolkien's use of language. The qualitative approach concentrates on intertextuality as a framework to cover the investigation of fantasy and its metaphorical relationship with reality. In presenting their methodology, the authors preclude that Tolkien "is a linguistic postmodernist" (8) before presenting much more than cursory evidence. Subsequent critical details may prove their statement to be true.

Using the constructs of metaphor and metonymy as a launching point for their discussion of reality juxtaposed with fantasy, the authors posit two misconceptions about fiction in general: escapism and realism. Namely that a certain type of fiction either provides an escape from everyday life or mimics it more closely than fantasy. Using the concepts of similarity and contiguity, they attempt to refute these misconceptions at the outset before diving into a closer analysis of *The Lord of the Rings* in specific. Basing their reading on the theories of Jacobson (10), stylistics and discourse are examined to determine how these two aspects create a relationship between the world of the text and the real world in the mind of the intended reader:

Fantastic texts, we should like to argue, regularly take a grasp on the world of our experience by means of metaphor, that is, through relationships of similarity, as opposed to "realistic" fiction which is mainly related to the world we know by means of metonymy, that is, through relationships of contiguity. (10)

To prove their position, *The Hobbit* is presented as metaphorical in nature, while *The Lord of the Rings* is a combination of metaphor and metonymy, in that both fantasy and realism abound. *The Hobbit* is pure quest and follows the narrative structure and program of similar children's literature from the 19<sup>th</sup> century, of which several examples are cited. In contrast, *The Lord of the Rings* is presented as "fantastic" by virtue of an extensive breakdown of descriptive scenes, character development, and subplot story-telling that exemplifies the realist novel of the late 19<sup>th</sup>, early 20<sup>th</sup> century.

Tolkien's epic narrative actually abounds in descriptions of the characters' outward appearance, their habitations and the landscapes they pass through during their quest. In these respects, *The Lord of the Rings*, in spite of its fantasy plot, is indebted to the nineteenth-century realist novel. (15)

Why the combination of realistic and fantastic details in *The Lord of the Rings*? The authors state that this mix lends to the willing suspension of disbelief when reading the text. But furthermore, the realism pulls the reader into the tale,

allowing for poetic faith in the more extraordinary details. In other words, the fantastic world is given a cloak of familiar cloth from which to operate. As we travel through strange and amazing worlds, we are comforted and equally horrified by the familiar details, intensifying our sympathetic response.

Concerning the method of intertextuality and discourse theory as applied in the analysis presented, the approach of providing a composite view of linguistic and thematic elements is unique, in that they are generally treated as disparate domains of inquiry. The Introduction of this work takes time to look at the narrative technique of *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* by seeking the “pre-text” that may have informed their composition at various points of interest. And so the realm of fairy tales and myth emerges preeminent. Irony and parody are emphasized as well as a variety of other features including pathetic fallacy as a means of characterizing the representation of fantastic space through which protagonists venture.

In order to further examine *The Lord of the Rings* and Tolkien’s style, the authors propose an examination of key word phrases and how they are used within the narrative passages to create a body of narratorial motifs and movements that define language and its various modes as unique within the corpus of English literature. Foundational to subsequent discussions, “Tolkien as a Stylist: Key Words and Key Collocations in *The Lord of the Rings*” describes a data-driven analysis of the work. Siepmann’s objective is to compare word selection and usage, unigram and bigrams, to curated sets of 19<sup>th</sup>- and 20<sup>th</sup>-century writings, both fiction and non-fiction, containing 30 and 94 million words respectively. A word or two-word phrase is considered to be key if it occurs at least three times and is outstandingly frequent compared to the baseline corpus.

With a comparison of word selection and phrasing, the concept of “overuse” surfaced a number of interesting facts surrounding Tolkien’s mastery of the English language. Concerning 19<sup>th</sup>-century terminology, he had a propensity to use about twice the number of key words. Phrasing for verb-adverb pairings, narrative constructs, and modalities of intent were also archaic. Additionally, descriptors for landscape features, and positioning of nature elements depend on obsolete or archaic forms of composition. Analysis of modern fiction from the early 20<sup>th</sup>-century corpus indicates that while the words were modern, they were placed within 19<sup>th</sup>-century structural patterns of speech, such that common English words are rendered strange to the eye of the reader. Words like “endless” and “fair” are repeatedly used in non-standard contexts for example. Addressing the common argument that Tolkien relied on his knowledge of Old English and epic tales, the analysis of keyword density between his translation of *Beowulf* and *The Lord of the Rings* is especially

noteworthy. Consideration is given to the verb *smite*, or the usage of its past tense *smote* in various passages.

When examining bigrams, the evidence points to a selection of everyday adjectives juxtaposed in unusual pairing with nouns, such that collocations of words create a distribution pattern which heightens the sense of adventure. For example “great” is a common adjective but paired frequently with abstract nouns that are decidedly archaic: “peril,” “weariness,” “deed.” Sometimes adjectives are combined to create a stronger impact of otherness: “great black mace.”

Part of Tolkien’s special gift as a writer appears to lie in this ability to craft literary turns of phrase from the most basic lexical material in the language, a feat which authors of lesser stature generally cannot accomplish, opting instead for more complex forms of words. (57)

A noteworthy outcome of the investigation into key n-grams in *The Lord of the Rings* is the degree to which Tolkien animated the landscape. Using contrasts of dark and light, anthropomorphism, and descriptive patterns of uncertainty to introduce the fantastic into an otherwise realistic journey, he balances themes of trust and terror to create dramatic tension. Finally, the common domains that emerge from the data driven analysis provide an insight into thematic areas of investigation: Darkness/light/color, geographical/location-based content, nature/plant life, time, distance, ethical values, etc. Especially useful is the appendix of Key Words exclusive to *The Lord of the Rings* (64-67).

In conclusion, the word counting, bigram analysis, collocation study, and semantic categorization details add up to evidence of Tolkien’s reliance on the 19<sup>th</sup>-century novel and his translation of *Beowulf*. He relies on his academic knowledge of linguistics, putting old words to new usage and forcing modern words to take on archaic significance. In this sense, the authors conclude that much like James Joyce or Virginia Woolf, Tolkien, according to Siepmann, should be considered a postmodernist.

The third chapter is purely analytic and provides a bridge between the statistical approaches of semiotic word analysis and the subsequent, more traditional literary narrative treatments. Continuing the theme of data-driven investigation, Siepmann’s next step is to query the narrative syntax of Tolkien’s work starting at the word, then phrase, and finally clause level of discourse. He looks for negative evidence, in other words, what is common usage that Tolkien eschews, before examining those attributes that are unique to *The Lord of the Rings*. Taking his findings, he examines two sample paragraphs to provide an exegesis of intent behind the use of everyday language in avoidance of the banal.

To contrast styles, the author looks at a passage from the Shire, which exhibits a familiar style, compared to a heroic scene cast in the “high” style of epic or myth.

Next, Thomas Kullmann takes over to examine the historic point of view attempting to identify the literary antecedents of *The Lord of the Rings*. As a novel of the mid-20<sup>th</sup> century, the trilogy follows the standard patterns, using direct speech to comprise 50 percent of the text (90). Narrative oversight comes from the point of view of the hobbits and their experiences while even maintaining the third-person voice. Explications and interpretations of events come from other characters rather than the narrator, so that narratorial intervention into the story is minimized. In other words, we do not get an omniscient point of view, but the more fantastic characters provide the insights: wizards, dwarves and elves seem to be more in touch than the “everyman” of Hobbiton.

Continuing his program in Chapter 4, “Points of View,” Kullmann brings to bear the historic analysis of themes and influences for *The Lord of the Rings*. Noting that just over 50 percent of the text is dialog between characters, he compares Tolkien’s narrative to epic and classic romance prose (90) while the narration is more modern in nature hewing to the conventions of 19<sup>th</sup> century writing tradition. The key narrative construct of realism from the point of view of the hobbits is contrasted with various other character types which bring into play degrees of the fantastic and supernatural. By using the hobbits’ point of view for what is real and their sense of wonder at what is “not real,” the emotions, ethics, and sense of fair play create a movement in not only space and time, but in that quintessential realm of spiritual maturity. For example, the transcendental beauty of the elves and their realm not only marks a way point in the journey of the fellowship, but also, using the technique of limited point of view, creates an intermediate agency between reality and fantasy: we see but through a glass darkly. Focalized vision creates metaphorical journeys for the reader.

Shifting points of view also serve to raise narrative tension. By separating the hobbits into two groups (Sam and Frodo, Merry and Pippin), the narrative spreads out like the landscape into a wider field of play. While the main narrative continues as the quest of the ring, Merry and Pippin introduce us to Fangorn, Gondor, Rohan, Helm’s Deep, and ultimately Minas Tirith, all highly mythic in nature if not reputation. Through this secondary journey we get a wider historical and mythical perspective on Middle-earth. In contrast the main journey of Frodo and Sam continues in the epic tradition of loneliness and subjectivity.

By examining these points of view, the author emphasizes Tolkien’s varied techniques in both character and narrative development of the story line. Noting that Tolkien relied upon his background in Old English and especially his translation of *Beowulf* for inspiration to characterize military communities such

as the Riders of Rohan and the defenders of Minas Tirith, Kullmann is not unearthing any new surprises. However, his contrast of parataxis and hypotaxis as defining these two cultures on scales of sophistication creates a narrative foreground both auditory and visual in nature against which events play out. The juxtaposition of styles is a statement both about the love of language and the registers of society in which that language is used to narrate the battle of good and evil. The one person who fluidly moves between societies, languages, and social registers is Gandalf. Kullmann spends some time looking at the wizard's point of view as both judge and jury, counselor and comrade in arms to various members of the fellowship. Ethical discussions come about through the pre-texts and contexts of Gandalf's stories and adventures. He is both a source of information about the history of the peoples and landscapes they travel through and a participant in that history, being almost as old as the elves. He mediates between realms and times, illustrating a state of mind while in the midst of telling stories. Gandalf's point of view, more than any other character's, is omniscient even though no one is a complete know-it-all.

If Chapter 4 was about personas and their points of view, the next chapter focuses on Landscape as a singularly unique presence in *The Lord of the Rings*. "Landscape Descriptions," while extensive in its review of the many descriptive passages, can be summed up as one of defining the landscape as a persona that moves narration forward. In other words, if the company does not get moving, the land will force them onward. "Why?" is the key issue addressed in this analysis. Why does Tolkien take the various scenery pieces and animate them with a force and a will of their own? Mountains and trees seemingly rage against the protagonists with a hatred equivalent to that of demons and orcs, lending a gothic darkness to the surroundings. The author posits three reasons for the personification of nature as an ancient malevolent force: glorify the English countryside by contrast, mirror at times the characters' state of mind, and inject a magical dimension to the story (131). Each has its own narrative tradition which is explored at length. There is a nice table laying out the metaphorical interrelationship of landscapes to characters' psychology (138) that hearkens to 19<sup>th</sup>-century romanticism and the gothic novel, using Ruskin's pathetic fallacy as a construct. The use of metonymic and metaphoric systems of signification for plants, trees, details of nature and the landscape is a means to also contrast the real and the supernatural.

The next two chapters look at "Speeches and Declarations" and "Storytelling" respectively. As previously noted, over 50 percent of *The Lord of the Rings* is direct speech, and these three types of speech are predominant. As with the chapter on Landscapes, most of the effort is in cataloging and analyzing the various passages that comprise each type of dialogue. Of note, only reciting poetry is not used for the rhetorical means of persuasion. It is purely for

entertainment. There are categories of speeches, such as those of welcome, prediction, and personal advice. Each has its purpose of persuading the audience to a point of view. Some are more classical in their format, and some such as that of the hobbits, tend toward plain talk. Manipulation as a key power of language is especially highlighted for Gollum. Higher born characters use archaic, epic speech for their own manipulative purposes, using fancy words to hide their desires. Noble words do not always equate to noble deeds.

Storytelling, in contrast to speech-making, is used to impart narrative information that otherwise would not be able to be conveyed. It tends to be more epic in nature and while there are 23 story tellers, each with their own style, the common purpose is to give historic context to the quest. Immediate, historic, and mythic timeframes categorize the type of information conveyed. (194) The three levels of the past that this body of knowledge creates establishes a timeline of remoteness and immediacy. Short and long time determine current reality and mythology with Gandalf as the mediator. The degenerate nature of current times, as seen in Gondor, only highlights the glory of former times as witnessed firsthand by the elves and wizards. Interestingly, speech that is prophecy becomes story where the character involved realizes that they participate directly in the tale. Storytelling, thus becomes a social activity, inviting the listener and the reader to participate in the adventure, where language becomes the basis of human interaction.

The analysis of “Poems and Songs,” of which there are more than 60 within *The Lord of the Rings*, posits that various recitations and performances serve the plot by advancing narrative development as much as to add entertainment. Kullmann notes four types of verse: Mythic, Functional, Bellicose, and Otherworldly. A handy table (230-233) catalogs a breakdown of the types and their schemas. The poems are then elucidated by their textual traditions and genres, mostly related to English folksongs. The chief purpose of this chapter is to show the breadth of Tolkien’s erudition and pretextual knowledge. Kullmann also notes that the poetry serves to give voice to a sort of transcendental experience (238) for the speaker, and therefore the reader. It opens up both to the possibility of a greater world beyond the current one and creates a bridge that crosses physical as well as metaphysical boundaries.

An additional aspect of poetic utterances is the philological one. Poems and songs allow the characters to play with words, explore archaic traditions, chant in other languages, and in essence create a commentary on language, literature, and by extension Old and Middle English, often the realm of folklorists and historians.

The penultimate chapter “Language and Character” appears a bit repetitious. This may be due to the fact that several of the preceding topics were independent papers republished here as loosely associated themes, each one

dealing with different aspects of language that the characters employ. In this dissection of the text, the author sets out to look at the “character by character” stylistics of direct speech. Before it was “Direct speech as storytelling,” “Direct speech presenting Point of View,” and so forth. Here it is the stylistics of Frodo, Gandalf, etc. as speakers. The chapter takes each major member of the fellowship and breaks down the registers and vocabulary they employ, be it epic or everyday content, placing these characters into specific literary traditions. Gandalf and Frodo are found to be the most flexible. Sam undergoes the most evolution. Gimli and Legolas represent the most traditional registers for their typology. Merry and Pippin use common English language as befitting their role of reality-based touchstones.

Concluding their work, the authors declare that *The Lord of the Rings* is firmly entrenched in the novel-writing tradition of English literature by virtue of its language and style. Spanning the epic to fairy tales, romances, and ultimately 19<sup>th</sup>- and early 20<sup>th</sup>-century realist novel, Tolkien called upon a vast field of pretexts for linguistic and literary input in composing *The Lord of the Rings*. This is evinced through the “presentation of a story through the point of view of a character” (297-98). Landscape features also mirror the 19<sup>th</sup>-century novel. They would like to see Tolkien given the same consideration as Shakespeare or Joyce. Comparing Tolkien’s vocabulary to Shakespeare’s, the authors note that he had over three millennia of literary tradition and word choices from which to pull, creating a similar linguistic versatility. The authors also compare Tolkien to Joyce, stating that both are modernists updating the epic with their writings, using various techniques and references to mythic and fictional precursors. The difference drawn between the two writers is that Joyce is firmly placed in the realist camp, while Tolkien is relegated to the fantasy aisle. And only serious writers get serious consideration.

This study aims to correct that mis-categorization by bridging the interpretive gap of, on one hand, the philological approach and the other more interpretive, modernist treatment. They posit that the tools of data mining that corpus linguistics provides can bridge this gap by showing the wealth of language, word usage, and grammar constructs both quantitatively and qualitatively. While some consider *The Lord of the Rings* low-brow or children’s literature, the corpus-driven stylistics examination has shown numerous similarities with high-brow style (304). Indeed some of the greatest value in this work is the many tables of data, word lists, and cataloging of stylistic elements revealed by computational analysis, automating what old-school philologists formerly had to do by hand. All in all, this work will serve as a valuable reference for the serious Tolkien scholar for many years to come, laying the groundwork for future studies into the artistry of Middle-earth.

—Sharon L. Bolding